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Brian P. Brown · Danny N. Bellenger · Wesley J. Johnston

The Implications of Business-to-Business and Consumer Market Differences for B2B Branding Strategy

Abstract

By integrating existing conceptual models and research findings, this effort examines the noteworthy differences between the B2B and the consumer market contexts and the implications of those differences on the formulation of B2B brand strategies. We introduce the B2B-Consumer Market Dimensions Continuum as a tool to identify key differences between the two markets. The continuum is used to suggest the branding approach that is most likely to be successful in a B2B organization's brand-building efforts.

Keywords: business-to-business marketing – brand strategy

Authors

B. P. Brown,
University of Massachusetts, Isenberg School of Management,
Amherst, MA, USA
E-Mail: bbrown32@gsu.edu

D. N. Bellenger · W. J. Johnston,
Georgia State University, Robinson College of Business,
Atlanta, GA, USA

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Introduction

Although consumer products marketers have just recently discovered the importance of relationship marketing, business-to-business (B2B) marketers have recognized it for decades. In turn, B2B marketers have recently begun to rely on brand-building strategies in a manner consistent with their consumer counterparts. As B2B marketers attempt to increase firm performance, they have turned to branding efforts as a central component of their overall corporate strategies. The case of the BASF Group, a chemical manufacturer, exemplifies this trend: "We don't make a lot of the products you buy. We make a lot of the products you buy better." This tagline from BASF's long-running advertising campaign is credited with elevating the firm to one of the world's most admired global companies and to elite status in the chemical industry category. Since the campaign's launch in 1989, BASF's North American sales have increased from $3.2 billion to $8 billion, and once only associated with magnetic recording tape, the BASF brand now stands for innovation, partnership, and technology leadership that helps its business partners make better products (Lamons 2005).

The BASF transformation is one case in a growing body of evidence in support of B2B marketers applying branding principles. Marketing practitioners have begun to reallocate resources accordingly. Spending by B2B marketers and the level of commitment to advertising demonstrated by market leaders is up according to industry trends. For example, according to American Business Media's Business Information Network, compared with 2004, B2B advertising spending grew 2.4% in 2005, and advertising revenue in B2B publications increased 5.4% (*BIN Spin*, 2006).

Although branding in consumer contexts has a rich literature, with few exceptions, it has been largely ignored as a significant area of focus by B2B academics (Kim et al. 1998; Low and Blois 2002; Mudambi, Doyle, and Wong 1997). The arguments for this oversight are ambivalent. That is, there is an assumption that business markets are too similar to consumer markets to warrant any dedicated exploration in business settings. At the same time, there is an assumption that the dynamics of organizational settings supersede the emotion-laden principles of brand strategy.

Although organizational buying researchers have formulated a general understanding of the uniqueness of business markets, a lack of understanding of branding and its role in B2B contexts remains. Thus, there is an increasing interest in the role of brands in industrial settings as illustrated by several conceptual and empirical studies (e.g., Bendixen, Bukasa, and Abratt 2004; Gordon, Cantone, and di Benedetto 1993; Low and Blois 2002; McQuiston 2004; Mudambi 2002; Mudambi et al. 1997). Extant literature and industry success stories suggest that brands can play an important role in organizational buying. Previous work has not brought together all of the various B2B versus consumer market differences nor have they suggested B2B branding strategies based on those differences. The aims of this effort are: (1) to discuss the differences in B2B versus consumer markets

that can impact the successful use of branding, and (2) to suggest the branding approach that is most likely to be successful in B2B contexts based on those differences.

The meaning and value of branding

Before examining the differences in B2B versus consumer markets that have a potential impact on the likely success of B2B branding strategy, it may be helpful to clearly define the meaning and value of branding. Kotler (1991, p. 442) defines a brand as "a name, term, sign, symbol, or design, or combination of them which is intended to identify the goods and services of one seller or group of sellers and to differentiate them from those of competitors". Thus, a brand is an identifier of some entity, with the notion that the brand name enables consumers to confidently identify one product from another.

The value that a brand has is captured in the concept of brand equity. Brand equity can be considered "from the consumer perspective as a utility, loyalty, or a clear, differentiated image not explained by product attributes and from a firm perspective as the incremental cash flow resulting from the product with the brand name compared with that which would result without the brand name" (Ailawadi, Lehmann, and Neslin 2003, p. 1). Similarly, Aaker (1996, p. 7) defines brand equity as "[a] set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name or symbol that add or subtract from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or to that firm's consumers". Aaker (1991) also suggests four dimensions of brand equity: brand awareness, perceived quality, brand associations, and brand loyalty.

Keller and Lehmann (2001) divide existing measures of brand equity into three categories: customer mind-set, product-market outcomes, and financial market outcomes. The customer mind-set perspective tends to assess an end consumer's psychological perspective of a brand, including his or her awareness, attitudes, associations, attachments, and loyalties toward the brand (Ailawadi et al. 2003). For example, Keller (1993) introduces the concept of customer-based brand equity as the differential effect of brand knowledge on a consumer's response to the marketing of the brand. Brand knowledge is conceptualized according to an associative network memory model in terms of brand awareness and brand image. Brand awareness includes elements of brand recall and recognition, and brand image includes the set of brand associations and their favorability, strength, and uniqueness.

The concept of a brand can best be thought of as a psychological phenomenon (Webster and Keller 2004). Brand awareness and brand image are two components of the psychological meaning of a brand. Customers must know what products and services are associated with a brand (brand awareness), what attributes and benefits the brand offers (brand value), and what makes the brand better and distinctive (brand image). Thus, much of the brand equity literature is considered from the standpoint of a consumer's perceptions about a particular brand. Although there is

an increased effort to capture a brand's financial value (e.g., Reinartz and Kumar 2000; Rust, Lemon, and Zeithaml 2004; Rust, Zeithaml, and Lemon 2000; 2004), brand value is often considered in terms of its more consumer-oriented connotations.

The value of branding is determined in large part by how much impact the brand has on the buyers purchase decision. Brand sensitivity is a psychological construct related to a buyer's decision-making process (Lachance, Beaudoin, and Robitaille 2003). Kapferer and Laurent (1988) introduced the brand sensitivity construct in a study comparing national brands with unbranded or private label brands. They recognized the need to measure variation in brand importance from one category to another and one buyer to another. Referring to an individual or buyer as brand sensitive means that brands play an important role in the psychological process that precedes the buying act (Lachance et al. 2003). Blomback (2005) notes the importance of studying brands and brand strategy as it affects a buyer's purchase decision. Brand strategies will have a greater effect when consumers are unable to thoroughly judge the quality of a purchase in advance and when the strategies are related to a product that influences the consumer's personal identity (Riezebos 2003). Blomback (2005) concludes that marketers need to understand brand sensitivity to understand a brand's potential market impact.

Because of the nature of business markets, some marketers have recognized that branding principles in B2B markets may need to differ from those in consumer markets. For example, Gordon et al. (1993) and Bendixen et al. (2004) validate the existence of brand value in industrial markets and identify specific differences between branding in consumer and business contexts. Webster and Keller (2004) propose that brand equity becomes more important depending on the complexity of the procurement problem, the scope and size of the buying unit, and the time required to make a purchase decision. Moreover, it is apparent that an industrial brand communicates value beyond the functionality of a particular product. In the B2B context, brand equity is "a perception that the brand/brand name conveys the likelihood of positive value to the buyer" (Kim et al. 1998, p. 3). McQuiston (2004) suggests that for industrial products, branding is a multidimensional construct that includes not only how the customer views the physical product, but also the logistics, customer support, and corporate image and policy that accompany the product. Ward et al. (1999, p. 88), notes that to the B2B marketer, a brand is "a distinctive identity that differentiates a relevant, enduring, and credible promise of value associations with a product, service, or organization that indicates the source of that promise".

This review of current thinking regarding the meaning and value of brands indicates that there is a need to extend branding research into industrial markets. As Mudambi et al. (1997) note, consumer branding strategies are not directly transferable to industrial markets because they fail to account for insights gained from research in organizational buying, buyer–supplier relationships, and industrial segmentation.

The B2B-Consumer Market Dimensions Continuum

Turning now to B2B versus consumer markets, Gilliland and Johnston (1997) imply that B2B and consumer markets significantly differ in contextual conditions, psychological conditions, and marketing variable conditions. Similarly, we contend that branding differs in business versus consumer markets because of business markets' unique contextual conditions, psychological conditions, product variables and marketing communication variables. The B2B-Consumer Market Dimensions Continuum (see Fig. 1) is proposed as a tool that allows comparisons between the two contexts. It illustrates how the two markets differ in terms of their general tendencies.

Contextual conditions

The notion of the purchase situation is a key consideration in organizational buying literature. Johnston and Lewin (1994) propose that the risk associated with organizational purchase situations ranges from low levels to high levels. Purchase situation factors can be categorized as those related to the company, product, and individuals within the firm. The novelty of the purchase, the complexity of the purchase situation, and, especially, the importance of the purchase situation are powerful determinants of a buying center's decision-making process (Johnston and Bonoma 1981).

The novelty of the purchase situation refers to "the lack of experience of individuals in the organization with similar purchase situations" (McQuiston 1989, p. 69). The novelty of a product/service purchase is expected to affect the level of a buyer's perceived risk. In a consumer behavior context, Heilman, Bowman, and Wright's (2000) theory of dynamic brand choice claims that the likelihood of choosing an "underdog" brand will be low when a consumer enters a new category, while the likelihood of selecting an "underdog" brand will increase with purchasing experience, as perceived risks for less-known alternatives decrease. In short, with experience in a category, consumers are expected to be more likely to choose a less-known brand. In an organizational behavior setting, Heide and Weiss (1995) suggest that buyers with more experience are likely to choose a known brand as a result of organizational memory. This apparent disagreement supports our call for additional study of brand influence in organizational buying contexts.

Product specific factors associated with the purchase situation, such as perceived risk, time pressure, and type of purchase, may influence selling firms' efforts to build brand equity (Sheth 1973). We expect that these factors influence a buying firm's propensity to be swayed by a product's or service's brand equity or, perhaps more pertinently, by the selling firm's reputation. Technical complexity and value for the item are likely to be positively correlated with the degree of perceived risk. Thus, a high value, technically complex, important-to-the-production-process purchase will have a high level of associated risk (Mitchell 1995).

	CONSUMER MARKET		BUSINESS MARKET
Contextual Conditions	Low	*1. Buying Situation Risk* ↔	High
	Fashion / Self-Expressive	*2. Product-Market Drivers* ↔	Technological / Utilitarian
	Individual	*3. Purchase Decision Process* ↔	Group
Psychological Variables	Social	*4. Type of Risk* ↔	Economic and Performance
	Impulse Purchases	*5. Impulsiveness* ↔	Rational Discourse
	External: Icons / Peers	*6. Reference Group Influencers* ↔	External: Best-in-class Internal: Experts
Product Variables	Product-Oriented	*7. Brand Strategy Approach* ↔	Company Oriented
	Product and Associated Imagery	*8. Product Value* ↔	Product and Associated Services
Marketing Communications Variables	Traditional / Broadcast	*9. Medium* ↔	Interactive / Personal
	Image-Based	*10. Content* ↔	Technical / Pedagogic

Fig. 1. The B2B-Consumer Market Dimensions Continuum

McQuiston (1989, p. 70) defines purchase importance as "the impact of a purchase on organizational profitability and productivity". The importance of a product, as indicated by the degree to which product specifications meet a buyer's perceived needs, is expected to affect the perception of the product/service brand (Kim et al. 1998). Valla (1982) suggests that three product categories can be used to

help explain variations in the degree of risk perceived in a buying situation: banal products, products of importance in the production process, and strategic products. Because of the importance of most purchases, industrial buyers are expected to differ from end consumers in terms of their general level of involvement and of the frequency of strategically important purchases. We expect that the heightened level of involvement in specific product categories is a factor directly related to an organization's or buyer's brand sensitivity.

Researchers have studied two areas of complexity in industrial buying: complexity of the purchase situation and complexity of the product. McQuiston (1989, p. 70) defines complexity of the purchase as "how much information the organization must gather to make an accurate evaluation of the product". McQuiston notes that, in general, studies of complexity find that the purchase situation's increased complexity leads to greater uncertainty for buying center members. Bendixen et al. (2004) point to research that indicates that branding may be more important in complex buying situations. We contend that this is the case because of the need for cues that signal the performance of a product/service and the need to manage risk in such situations. The fact that B2B purchase decisions involve more people also adds to the complexity of the process. Buying centers may include representatives from a number of disparate functional areas, each with distinct functional specifications in mind. The concerns of all of these members must be addressed by the supplier thus the brand must communicate a wide range of meanings.

In a business context, products tend to be more technologically advanced than in a consumer context. The buyer is most concerned with functionality, particularly as it pertains to vendor claims. Products tend to follow linear trends in business contexts because of technical advancement. In addition, purchases are made within an "ideology of rational choice" (Minett 2002, p. 69). That is, there tends to be at least some public, rational discourse regarding the purchase. Finally, there tends to be an objective, measurable outcome in business contexts. As a result of the formality of organizational buys, purchases are likely to progress through purchase stages ranging from problem recognition to postpurchase analysis. In consumer contexts, products tend to be lifestyle oriented. Consciously or subconsciously, consumers are concerned with whether a product is consistent with personal image, values, and social approval. Thus, consumer products are likely to follow more cyclical trends.

McQuiston (2004) views branding on the consumer and industrial sides as representative of a promise to consumers, but he suggests that the makeup of the brand promise differs in each context. After a product meets a consumer's fundamental physical requirements, the promise of the brand tends to be more intangible, offering the consumer the "emotional security" of a recognized brand name. On the industrial side, a brand represents a multidimensional promise of value that includes factors beyond the promise of a physical good, including augmented services and company reputation.

The nuances of each context suggest unique marketing approaches and, thus, unique branding approaches. Industrial goods may require buyers to be educated on tangible, quantifiable benefits. Consumer goods may require that consumers de-

velop psychological associations and imagery (Minett 2002). On the basis of these important contextual extremes, we expect that the role of brands will differ in the following ways:

Proposition 1: The B2B context in general has a higher level of perceived risk than the consumer context thus B2B buyers are more likely to select known brands and to rely more heavily on technological/utilitarian factors than self-expressive factors in brand evaluations.
Proposition 2: B2B brand evaluation and selection processes are conducted by larger groups (buying centers) rather than individuals or households thus the brand must communicate a wider range of meanings which includes such elements as delivery and maintenance.

Psychological conditions

Organizational buyers are likely to be brand sensitive and to select well-known brands under certain conditions, including when the risks of organizational or personal consequences are high (Hutton 1997). Furthermore, when there is a high perception of risk, there tends to be a propensity to "group buy" or share in the risk of the particular purchase (Mitchell 1995). Valla (1982) suggests that the characteristics of the buying center (e.g., the number of people, the nature of the decision-making process, interpersonal relationships) are determinants of the level of perceived risk. Highly structured purchase procedures can offset high levels of psychosocial risk (Newall 1977).

Some individuals are innately more risk averse than others. Moreover, there are intrinsic motivational factors associated with risk that are naturally programmed into a person's personality (Mitchell 1995). A substantial amount of literature suggests that individual risk minimization or avoidance is a key motivating factor in the industrial buying process (e.g., Puto, Patton, and King 1985; Qualls and Puto 1989).

The type of risk experienced by end consumers is likely to differ from that of organizational buyers in both magnitude and nature. The end consumer is likely to be affected by group and/or personal risk; though in certain household scenarios (e.g., durable goods), the adverse consequences of a purchase is likely to be limited to a single individual. In addition, the choices of an end consumer are likely to include both luxuries and necessities, whereas organizational buyers are unlikely to purchase luxuries.

Hawkins, Best, and Coney (2004) distinguish among five types of perceived risk: social risk, financial risk, time risk, effort risk, and physical risk. Financial, time, and effort risks are broadly considered economic risks related to waste or inefficiency. Social risk is the risk that a purchase may not meet social acceptance by peers. Performance risk pertains to risk due to a likelihood of product failure (Henthorne and LaTour 1992). Assael (1987) notes that the influence of performance risk is greatest when a buyer is dealing with a technically complex or unfamiliar product. Midgley (1983) considers variations on the level of search based on prod-

uct type. He categorizes products as functional, hedonic, and symbolic. Although all types of products might have some level of economic risk, performance risk is likely to be more important with functional products. Thus, performance risk is likely to be more pervasive in B2B settings than in consumer settings.

There is a level of social risk in organizational buying related to the perceived risk of a purchased product not meeting with the approval of other members of the decision-making unit (Henthorne and LaTour 1992). However, we expect that social risk is of far less significance to the organizational buyer than to the end consumer. Similarly, although economic risk is relative, we expect that economic and performance risks are more dominant factors in organizational buying.

In summary, an important distinction between business and consumer markets is the type and level of anxiety a buyer experiences when making a purchase. The role of brands as risk reducers is likely to differ according to the setting. In B2B buying, brand choice may play some role in reducing social risk, but branded products are more likely to reduce perceived economic and performance risks for organizational buyers than for end consumers.

The self-expressive nature of consumer products and the individual purchase decision process in consumer contexts often lead to impulse buying. Organizational buyers are unlikely to make impulsive purchases. The business market context almost certainly requires discussion among individuals within the prospective organization and personal contact between the buying firm and the selling firm (Minett 2002). Both the technical nature of the product and the group purchase decision process suggest some level of rational discourse.

Organizational buyers are assumed to focus on purchase attributes that include price, quality, performance, and services. Because such criteria tend to be valued differently by different members of the buying center, debate is required. Moreover, the risk involved in an organizational purchase is likely to compel buyers to consult informal, personal sources of information (De Chernatony and McDonald 1998), including contacts with a sales representative or other personal relationships. Finally, because of the tendency to form long-term and more collaborative relationships in business settings, organizational buyers are faced with the challenge of convincing both themselves and other parties about any proposed relationship (Minett 2002).

The concepts of reference groups and opinion leadership have been widely studied in consumer settings (e.g., Bearden and Etzel 1982; Bhattacharya, Rao, and Glynn 1995; Feick and Price 1987; Schouten and McAlexander 1995). There has been limited research on these phenomena in organizational settings (Greve 1998). According to social comparison theory (Festinger 1954), reference group influence refers to situations in which a person or group of people significantly influences another person's behavior. The aspiration levels of individuals are determined by the performance of similar others, and they tend to compare themselves with referent others for self-assessment or self-enhancement (Greve 1998). Opinion leaders are group members whose actions and opinions are likely to have a strong influence on those of other members of the group (Webster 1970). According to consumer literature, consumers rely on opinion leaders to reduce the

risk of certain purchases (Sheth and Venkatesan 1968). Consumer marketers often identify and study opinion leaders and even integrate them directly into their marketing communications as endorsers (Hawkins et al. 2004; Minett 2002).

Webster (1970) concludes that the influence of opinion leaders is rare in organizational settings. However, his findings were based on qualitative interviews with only 50 buyers and were susceptible to methods bias. Nevertheless, his study suggests that opinion-leader companies have similar characteristics, including their generally larger size, commitment to new product development, progressive top management, and financial success. Martilla's (1971) study of word-of-mouth communication in industrial markets counters Webster's findings. Martilla attempted to verify whether the consumer product adoption process applied to industrial markets. He found that there are indeed opinion leaders within industrial firms and that these opinion leaders are an important factor in industrial purchase decisions. Specifically, he found that buyers reported seeking information and opinions from opinion leaders within their own firms as well as in competing firms. Furthermore, he identified several characteristics of individual opinion leaders, including their level of perceived expertise and their frequency and depth of exposure in product literature and trade journals compared with non-opinion leaders.

Recent literature has demonstrated that the study of reference groups in organizational contexts can have strategic advantages. Fiegenbaum and Thomas (1995) suggest that reference groups are found in organizational settings in the form of "strategic groups". These are typically organizations that are known to be "best-practice" leaders in their respective industries. Through interorganizational signaling and imitation (Porter 1980), members of one strategic group tend to adjust their strategic behavior toward an appropriate group reference point. In addition, strategic groups tend to serve as "benchmarks" for firms actively repositioning their strategies. As such, in this context, reference groups play a normative role by establishing standards and norms and a comparison point for making judgments and comparative evaluations. Massini, Lewin, and Greve (2005) found that innovative firms tend to consider different benchmarks of comparison more than their less innovative counterparts. They found that innovative firms compare themselves with, compete with, and try to differentiate from other innovative firms. In contrast, the majority of firms compare themselves with and conform to a broader group of firms. Thus, innovative firms tend to select different reference groups compared with less innovative firms.

In summary, consumer marketing literature has established that consumers explicitly seek out information or observe the behavior of reference group members and/or opinion leaders. Although the business marketing literature has dedicated fewer resources to the study of organizations as reference groups or the influence of intrafirm or interfirm opinion leaders, it is evident that there is theoretical and empirical support for these phenomena. In both contexts, reference groups and opinion leaders may provide information designed to reduce the risk of product purchases and influence behavior. However, several key distinctions are evident because of the unique product-market drivers and purchase decision processes of

each context. Thus, the roles of brands are likely to differ in each context. Although consumers may be inclined to purchase brands endorsed by celebrity icons, such an approach is likely to be insufficient in a business setting because of the complexity of most industrial purchases and the roles of other buying center members. In business settings, buyers are more likely to be influenced by objective and expert testimonials or the actual performance of referent firms.

On the basis of these distinct psychological conditions, we expect the following:

Proposition 3: Brands are likely to affect primarily economic and performance risks in business settings and primarily social risks in consumer settings.
Proposition 4: Branding in business contexts has a greater need to promote a process of rational discord than is typically required in consumer contexts.
Proposition 5: Brand selection by organizational buyers is more likely to be influenced by experts and best-in-class organizations, whereas consumers are more likely to be influenced by aspirational role models.

Product variables

In branding literature, researchers tend to study branded products such as those in the consumer packaged goods area. However, there is a growing stream of research that focuses on corporate branding phenomena (e.g., Aaker and Keller 1998; Brown 1998; Brown and Dacin, 1997). In discussions of a brand's effect on a buyer, corporate brands and product brands must be separated because it is common in organizational marketing for buyers to talk about vendors as brands (e.g., IBM, DuPont, BASF, Cisco).

Literature suggests that there is a continuum of corporate branding endorsement levels. At one end of the spectrum is what may be referred to as umbrella branding, corporate branding, or a "branded house" strategy (e.g., IBM, General Electric). A corporate branding strategy refers to "a systematically planned and implemented process of creating and maintaining a favorable reputation of an organization and its constituent elements, by sending signals to stakeholders using the corporate brand" (Van Riel and Van Bruggen 2002, p. 242). At the other end of the spectrum is what may be referred to as the product brand or a "house-of-brands" strategy (e.g., Procter & Gamble). A product-brand strategy refers to the use of a brand name that is separate from the company's name on an individual offer or a line of similar offers (Blomback 2005).

An important difference between business markets and consumer markets is that business markets tend to rely on an umbrella branding approach. Typically, organizational brand names bear the company's name (Michell, King, and Reast 2001; Shipley and Howard 1993). De Chernatony and McDonald (1998) note that in any purchase, organizational buyers' main concern is with the supplier's corporate identity, as opposed to any specific product. According to Gordon et al. (1993), this tendency has important implications. First, the company name and its reputation, not individual product brands, are the main discriminator. Second, in

many business contexts, brand loyalty is synonymous with firm loyalty. According to Mudambi et al. (1997), company reputation lies at the heart of industrial branding strategy. Thus, a buyer's evaluation of an industrial product will include not only consideration of the functional benefits of a product, but also an assessment of the people in the company in terms of their skills, attitudes, behavior, modes of communication, and speed of response (Michell et al. 2001).

An effective corporate branding approach tends to offer advantages to the vendor and buyer. For the vendor, it enables a portfolio of products to benefit from one corporate identity. This is particularly relevant in B2B contexts because of the shorter brand life cycles in industrial markets, as well as the opportunity to develop points of differentiation beyond functionality. In addition, managing a single corporate brand tends to be cost effective (De Chernatony and McDonald 1998). Moreover, loyalty toward a firm is likely to include the firm, its products, and its channel members throughout the supply chain (Gordon et al. 1993). Michell et al. (2001) add that in more commoditized markets, the use of the manufacturer corporate name appears to offer a greater likelihood of success than the use of individual product-brand names. Regardless of the market, corporate reputation appears to enhance value and tends to be difficult for competitors to imitate (Grant 1991; Michell et al. 2001). For the buyer, a supplier with an established corporate identity implies the formation of a value-added relationship with a firm, rather than the short-term benefits of a specific product or service (De Chernatony and McDonald 1998).

These benefits can be related to several unique characteristics of industrial marketing, including the importance of reputation and buyer–seller relationships, the nature of the decision-making process, and the challenge of communicating company benefits. Levitt (1967) investigated the extent of the advantages of well-established companies compared with little-known or unknown companies. He attempted to determine how the credibility of highly reputable companies affected the judgments of buyers, what he referred to as a "source effect". Indeed, for complex industrial products or materials, a company's positive reputation positively affected its prospect's buying decisions. More specifically, companies with solid reputations had a greater chance of being considered in the initial stages of a purchase decision and of gaining early adoption of their new products. Importantly, Levitt found that "[w]hen it comes to the most important and most risky of customer actions—actually deciding to buy or reject a new product—assuming the various suppliers' products to be equal in all respects, source credibility exerts a dominant influence over other considerations" (Levitt 1967, p. 18). Thus, a key consequence of corporate branding efforts is the establishment of a positive company reputation.

In an experimental approach, Levitt (1967) discussed that a company's reputation can be instrumental in a bidding supplier's success at "getting a foot in the door". The familiarity with or the reputation of a brand or vendor is often used as an initial screening criterion in buying processes (Moller and Laaksonen 1986). According to Heide and Weiss (1995), buyers' two key decisions are the consideration decision and the choice decision. In the awareness stage of the decision

process, buyers consider the available potential vendors. They then narrow the alternatives to a more limited consideration set. Favorable attitudes toward a vendor among the diverse members of the buying group can exert a significant influence throughout the buying process. Indeed, Mudambi et al. (1997) found that the intangible associations attached to a market leader included less risk and the need not to explain or justify the choice.

A potential vendor's relationship with an organization is likely to affect inclusion in a more limited consideration set. Business-to-business customers tend to rely on fewer vendors with long-term contracts for a greater percentage of their needs and, indeed, develop coordinated or working partnerships with each as a means to cope with uncertainty (e.g., Achrol, Reve, and Stern 1983; Anderson and Narus 1990; Pfeffer 1978). As a result, sellers that are considered relationship vendors are likely to be evaluated more on trustworthiness, reliability, and corporate credibility. In contrast, those that are considered only transaction vendors or non-vendors are likely to be evaluated solely on product performance, pricing, and tangible service attributes (Webster and Keller 2004).

Levitt's (1967) study confirms that the greater the personal risk to the sales prospect, the more persuasion it takes to switch from a current product or vendor to a new one. Moreover, customers tend to demonstrate levels of loyalty to their vendors because of the recognition that repeated patronage (as a "regular customer") may be a means to optimize satisfaction and grow the relationship with the seller (Zeithaml 1981). The findings of the IMP Group imply that corporate brands play an important role in the buyer–seller relationship because of the value of company reputation and because the interaction between both parties tends to affect the relationship over time (De Chernatony and McDonald 1998; Hakannson 1982).

McQuiston (2004) states that in business markets, loyalty is often directed more toward the entire company than a specific brand, and the company's standing in the industry and its overall reputation are considered a part of the brand. He suggests that the desire for a relationship with a company with a solid reputation is due to the increased perceived risk of the generally technically complex product offerings. The promise of value that a supplier of a good reputation has can serve to reduce this risk. McQuiston supports this point by conducting a case study with a Finnish steel company. He found that the company's strong corporate image and reputation lessened the perceived risk associated with purchase and buyers' cognitive dissonance.

The intangibility of a vendor's products and services is often difficult to communicate. Shostack (1977) implies that the greater the weight of intangible elements in a market entity, the more difficult it is for a marketer to describe its benefits precisely. Conversely, a buyer will have a more difficult task in evaluating and ultimately selecting such a market offering. A good reputation can help offset this uncertainty (Levitt 1967). Business marketing researchers have concluded that when buyers evaluate industrial products, intangible attributes such as reputation and corporate image can be of equal or greater importance than tangible, physical product attributes.

Business-to-business marketing tends to focus on the tangible, customized product as well as the corresponding augmented services in a purchase decision. Functional elements tend to be the most relevant, though emotional and self-expressive benefits may come into play. The differences between business and consumer markets are likely to affect a buyer's perception of brand value. Ultimately, the role and effects of branding in terms of communicating value are likely to differ, depending on the setting.

Mudambi et al.'s (1997) "pinwheel of brand value" is a conceptual framework that helps illustrate the unique nature of brand value in industrial marketing. They posit that brand value is a function of the expected price and the expected performance of tangible and intangible attributes. Brand value is composed of four performance components that have tangible and intangible elements. "Product performance" refers to the core, physical product that is at the center of a brand's value. "Distribution performance" refers to the product's ease of ordering, availability, and speed of delivery. "Support services performance" involves issues such as technical support, training, and financial support. Last, "company performance" includes all aspects of the company, including its reputation, perceived experience in different industries, and financial stability. Thus, an industrial buyer must consider several categories of tangible and intangible attributes to determine brand value.

Mudambi (2002) identifies three bundles of attributes that are relevant to industrial buyers: the product, the augmented services, and branding. Product attributes include price and physical product properties. Augmented services attributes include technical support services and ordering and delivery services. Last, branding attributes include general name awareness, the brand's reputation, and purchase loyalty. On the basis of a cluster analysis of the precision-bearings market, Mudambi found that firms differ on the importance of branding attributes. In general, "highly tangible" firms were product oriented and expressed less interest in the intangible aspects of product offers. "Branding receptive" firms perceived branding elements and service aspects to be relatively important. Last, "low interest" firms tended to be indifferent to branding elements and augmented services. Thus, Mudambi concludes that branding is not equally important to all companies, to all customers, or in all purchase situations. The role of the brand in communicating value is likely to be affected by various factors, including the importance of branding to the firm and the perceived risk of purchase.

In summary, the perceived value of a purchase is likely to vary depending on the context. Accordingly, the role of brands is likely to vary depending on the context. McQuiston (2004) contends that for industrial products, branding is a multidimensional construct that includes not only how the customer views the physical product, but also ancillary factors, such as the logistics, customer support, company image, and corporate policies that accompany the product. Beyond the physical product, buyers look to brands to communicate value beyond physical performance. Another factor integral to a brand's success is a manufacturer's ability to deliver products and support services, often through intermediaries, reliably and efficiently. Finally, McQuiston suggests that because loyalty in industrial markets

is often directed at the entire company rather than a specific brand, a company's goodwill and overall reputation in an industry are also considered a part of the brand. Because of the importance of company reputation and augmented services to the industrial buyer, we expect that branding in B2B contexts differs in the following ways:

Proposition 6: Compared with end consumers, organizational buyers are concerned more with company reputation than with the product-brand reputation.
Proposition 7: Compared with consumer brands, B2B brands communicate both tangible attributes, such as price and performance, and intangible attributes, such as reputation, distribution, and support services.

Marketing communications variables

Gilliland and Johnston (1997, p. 16) argue that "the inherent differences between [B2B] marketing and consumer marketing results in important differences in how marketing communication tools are processed and acted on by their targets". Although both consumer and B2B marketers rely on a variety of tools to promote their brands, the content communicated and the mediums used tend to differ. Thus, the communication strategies and tools are likely to vary according to the technological and functional attributes of a product and the makeup of the decision-making unit.

As do consumer marketers, B2B marketers use a wide variety of communication tools. The most frequently used tools tend to include the sales force, trade shows, trade magazines, sales materials, promotional techniques, public relations, and lobbying. Personal selling is the most important communication tool for the B2B marketer (Jackson, Keith, and Burdick 1987; Malaval 2001). It involves much more than an organization's sales force. For example, O'Hara (1993) notes that trade shows are a variation of face-to-face selling and are commonly used to supplement other personal selling programs. Parasuraman (1981) found that trade shows rank second behind on-site selling in influencing industrial purchasers' buying decisions.

Business marketing researchers suggest that the relative importance of various promotional elements varies across products, purchase situations, and stages (Jackson et al. 1987). Lilien (1983) found that trade shows are more likely to be used for technically complex products and customers who are highly involved. Patti (1977) established that personal selling was most important in all buying situations and purchase stages. Though not as important as personal selling, technical literature has also been found to be an important promotional element across all product types (Jackson et al. 1987). Traynor and Traynor (1989; see also De Chernatony and McDonald 1998) determined that suppliers found it most important to promote their brands through the sales force, followed by advertising in trade magazines, trade shows, technical seminars, sales promotion materials, direct mail advertising, packaging, and, last, newspapers/television/radio advertising. Thus, because of the complex and technical nature of industrial products and buyers' general interest in

building relationships, the sales force plays a particularly critical role in personally communicating a business brand's key attributes. Although B2B marketers may rely less on broadcast and print advertising, advertising in these contexts can be used to reach buyers who are not normally reached by salespeople. Instead of being a primary vehicle, in general, advertising is used to supplement the efforts of salespeople and to reduce the cost per sales call (Jackson et al. 1987).

Relative to the use of advertising, Gilliland and Johnston (1997) propose that the unique nature of B2B buying must be framed according to a buyer's contextual viewing conditions, the advertisement itself, and the contextual conditions of the ad; that is, the emotional and rational reactions of a buyer, as well as external influencers, must be considered. Relying on the elaboration likelihood model, Petty and Cacioppo (1986) suggest that the assumption that organizational buyers are somehow immune to the emotional content of an advertising message is limiting. Instead, both the cognitive and the affective routes to persuasion must be taken into account.

A consequence of the different contexts of business and consumer marketing is that their marketing communication mediums and content must be appropriately adapted. Turley and Kelley (1997) compare the advertising content of B2B services with that of consumer services. On the basis of the generally accepted premises that distinguish between the two domains and organizational buyers' need for rational justifications, they hypothesized that rational appeals would be more frequent in B2B settings. They found significant differences between the message appeals and concluded that the general tone of the two types of ads was indeed different.

In summary, B2B marketers are likely to emphasize different mediums and include different content in their message compared with consumer marketers. Because of the different contexts, brands require a different communication approach. In B2B settings, brand attributes require communication in a more interactive and even personal manner than traditional consumer techniques. In addition, in B2B settings, brand stimuli tend to require technical messages compared with the iconic messages typically used in consumer settings. Thus, we expect that B2B marketing communication execution differs from consumer marketing execution as follows:

Proposition 8: Brand value in business contexts tends to be communicated more through personal or interactive selling rather than the traditional broadcast media generally used in consumer contexts.
Proposition 9: The message used to communicate brand value in B2B contexts tends to require a higher level of technical content rather than the iconic content often used in consumer contexts.

Discussion and implications

As discussed previously, branding's meaning and use in B2B settings are likely to be sufficiently different from those in consumer settings. This research sug-

gests that the differences can be categorized as contextual conditions, psychological conditions, product variables, and marketing communications variables. Brand strategies need to be appropriately adapted to have the greatest benefit. The B2B-Consumer Market Dimensions Continuum suggests that each market has unique tendencies. Marketing practitioners must address these variations in the development of their marketing strategies.

Based on the differences between B2B and consumer settings, the brand strategy for business markets calls for the following elements to ensure the greatest likelihood of success. Note that each of these suggestions is derived from the discussion in the third section and that each warrants additional study.

Contextual Issues. Because organizational buying is enveloped in aspects of risk, marketers should use branding as a mechanism that lowers the perceived risk of business buying by insuring against purchase situation problems. Furthermore, unlike their consumer marketing counterparts, B2B marketers must highlight technological elements supplemented with an appropriate level of self-expressive elements. Finally, they must make a concerted effort to understand how each member of the buying center reacts to branding and the cumulative effect of brand power on the group. For example, IBM's "Water cooler" television spot promotes its technology leadership in addition to its capability of bringing organizations together to create innovative new ideas (www.ibm.com). Thus, it reinforces its image as a company that understands the gravity of organizational decision-making while finding an appropriate balance between offering a technological and self-expressive offering.

Psychological Issues. Though organizational buyers primarily contend with economic and performance risks, marketers need to actively use brands as a means of lowering the social risks of buying as well. Brands must contain and explain the aspects of economic and performance criteria. Additionally, rather than being impulsive choices, brands must have an air of rational discourse. That is, certain brands should stand for the most rational of choice. Finally, B2B marketers should appeal to opinion leaders and reference groups. Brands should be positioned to appeal to specific reference groups as best-in-class examples for purchases in appropriate instances. Also, internal experts may need to be co-opted by brand marketers to serve as champions during purchase deliberations.

Product Issues. Brands need to be identified with companies and the relationship that companies bring to a customer. Thus, brands must signify more than the promise of the tangible product. They must convey all the supporting services inherent in a company's product-market offering as well. For example, long recognized for its networking and enterprise products, CISCO Systems has increased marketing spending in support of its firewall and network-oriented security tools as a supporting service (www.eWeek.com).

Marketing Communications Issues. Brands must develop an interactive and personal dimension for each buying center member. Moreover, they must be perceived as having a technical dimension as well as a more emotionally-charged dimension. BASF's "We don't make a lot of the products you buy." campaign exemplifies this approach as it communicates a distinct personality and its chemi-

cal offerings. The copy of one of its print advertisements speaks of the durability, elasticity, and minimal rolling resistance of its plastics as well as its improved processes, increased quality and lower costs as the backdrop of an action-oriented in-line skating motif (www.basf.com). Thus, brands must be appropriately "hard", in the sense of functionality and problem-solving capabilities, and "soft", in terms of personality and various intangible attributes, in communicating with buying center members.

Conclusion

Marketing researchers have acknowledged that within organizational contexts, there is variance; brands do not play a critical role in all scenarios. Several new attributes need to be developed for brands if they are to communicate with business buyers effectively. The consumer packaged goods approach to branding offers some insight but falls short of the necessary elements required in B2B branding. The B2B-Consumer Market Dimensions Continuum highlights where branding, as it is currently developed, needs to be significantly improved. Future research should be dedicated to determining the conditions that are likely to be present when firms influence an organizational buyer's propensity to buy branded products or services versus less-known ones. Each of the propositions presented in the third section is based on current concepts and are deserving of future research.

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